The Alternative Models *Framework*

Eight development models English academies should be studying, each broken down with the structural decision, what it produced and the principle that transfers regardless of budget.

For academy directors, technical directors, coaching education founders and independent consultants in professional football development.

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Book a call

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How to use this document

Eight models. Eight structural decisions made by clubs operating in very different contexts with very different resources. None of them is a blueprint.

This document is a reference for practitioners who want to examine the structural choices in their own programme with more precision than the conventional frameworks provide. Each entry describes one thing a club did differently, what it produced and what the principle looks like when you strip away the budget and the context.

The Architecture Audit from the email course applies here. Three questions run underneath every entry:

> Which structural choices in your programme are deliberate? You made them consciously, you know why and you can explain the reasoning.
>
> Which are inherited? You run them because they were already running when you arrived or because every programme at your level runs them.
>
> Which have you tested the assumption behind? You know what you are assuming the choice produces. You have checked whether it is producing that.

Read the model closest to your current challenge first. If your immediate problem is measurement and assessment, start with AZ Alkmaar. If it is recruitment, start with Brighton, Brentford or Midtjylland. If it is infrastructure, start with Benfica. If it is philosophy and consistency, start with Red Bull or Ajax. If it is constraint and identity, start with Athletic Bilbao. If it is the relationship between education and development, start with Right to Dream.

The two questions at the end of each entry are the ones to sit with. They are not rhetorical. They are diagnostics.

Academy directors

Models 1–6

1. AZ Alkmaar Netherlands / Eredivisie

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

Most academies assess players against the same criteria regardless of position. A technically strong performance earns credit whether the player is a goalkeeper, a central midfielder or a wide forward. AZ Alkmaar rejected that approach. From U9 upwards, every player in their system is assessed against benchmarks designed specifically for their position, built in collaboration with Dutch academic institutions and updated as the research base develops.

The practical difference is significant. A central midfielder at AZ isn't asked to demonstrate generic technical quality. They're asked to demonstrate the specific cognitive and technical behaviours that research identifies as predictive for a central midfielder at elite level: decision-making speed under fatigue, positional awareness in transition, passing accuracy under pressure in tight spaces. The benchmark is precise because the question being asked is precise.

Psychological profiling is integrated into the process rather than treated as a welfare add-on. AZ have worked with sports psychology researchers to measure decision-making under physical fatigue, the specific condition under which players have to perform in matches, rather than measuring psychology in isolation from physical load. The feedback a player receives after a session maps directly to the benchmarks for their position.

The curriculum was designed with Dutch academic institutions rather than adapted from coaching manual templates. The distinction matters: the session design reflects what the research says produces development, not what coaching tradition says looks like development.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

AZ operate one of the smallest first-team budgets in the Eredivisie top six. Between 2019 and 2024, they generated more than €150 million in transfer revenue from academy graduates (Boardroom, 2024), with Teun Koopmeiners sold to Atalanta for approximately €14-15m (AZ retaining a sell-on clause), Calvin Stengs to Nice and Myron Boadu to Monaco among the headline figures.

Around 50% of AZ first-team minutes in recent seasons have been played by academy graduates, with typically four to six homegrown players starting regularly (WFS 2019; NorCal Coaching Education study visit, 2024). In 2022-23, AZ under-19s won the UEFA Youth League, the first Dutch club to achieve it. Their path to the final included a 3-0 win over Barcelona and a 4-0 win over Real Madrid. They defeated Hajduk Split 5-0 in the final.

The economic case is clean. AZ are competing in and winning European youth competition, generating consistent transfer revenue and fielding academy players at first-team level, whilst carrying a wage bill a fraction of the size of the clubs they're outperforming at youth level.

THE PRINCIPLE

When your measurement is position-specific, your coaching becomes position-specific. When your coaching is position-specific, the feedback your players receive is precise enough to change behaviour. Generic assessment produces generic development. The AZ model is the argument that precision in measurement is the structural precondition for precision in development.

AT YOUR LEVEL

Pick one position your programme develops most. Write down what technically excellent looks like for that position at U14, at U16 and at U18 in your system, not in general terms. Then check your current assessment criteria against what you've written. How much overlap is there?

If you asked your U12 lead coach and your U18 lead coach to describe what a technically excellent player in that position looks like, independently and without preparation, would their answers describe the same player?

2. FC Midtjylland Denmark / Danish Superliga

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

European academy recruitment runs on reputation. Scouts travel to known clubs in known leagues, identify players with established profiles and assess them against criteria that reflect what elite football has always valued. The assumption built into the process is that the best talent concentrates where the established academies are. FC Midtjylland asked whether that assumption holds.

It doesn't. FC Midtjylland built their recruitment model under Matthew Benham's ownership, in partnership with Smartodds, his sports analytics company. Benham sold his stake in the club in 2023 to Anders Holch Povlsen. The model described here reflects what Benham built and what the club continues to operate. The question at its centre is not where are the best-known players but where is talent underpriced. The shift in question produces a different answer every time and a different scouting map.

In practice, Midtjylland's recruitment extends globally, with sustained investment in West Africa, particularly Nigeria and Ghana, where the club identified athleticism and technical quality that European scouts were systematically undervaluing. The model doesn't rely on watching established academies. It relies on finding markets where the gap between actual quality and perceived quality is wide enough to generate a structural return.

The Guldminen school, operated in partnership with ISI (Idraetsfriskolen), sits at the centre of Midtjylland's player development approach. It is a state-accredited institution combining the Danish national curriculum with daily football and handball training. Players develop academically and technically simultaneously, not in competition with each other for the same hours.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

FC Midtjylland won four Danish Superliga titles between 2015 and 2024: 2014-15, 2017-18, 2019-20 and 2023-24. They compete regularly in European group stages on a budget a fraction of the size of the clubs they face. Notable players recruited and developed under the model include Pione Sisto, discovered in East Africa and sold to Celta Vigo. Evander, a Brazilian recruit, was sold to Portland Timbers for approximately $10 million.

Benham's approach at Brentford, which he continues to own, mirrored the same principles during the period both clubs operated under his ownership. Both clubs have been studied by academic researchers examining data-driven club management. The Midtjylland model is a replicable system, not a one-off experiment contingent on a single owner. The fact that it persisted through an ownership change is evidence of that.

THE PRINCIPLE

The question your recruitment process asks determines where it looks. If the question is which players have the strongest reputation, the answer will always cluster around the same markets. If the question is where is talent underpriced, the answer leads somewhere different and the return is structurally higher because the competition for those players is lower.

AT YOUR LEVEL

Where does your academy currently recruit? List the postcodes, the feeder clubs, the schools. Now ask: is that geography the result of a deliberate decision about where the best talent is for your programme or is it where you've always looked?

If a rival academy with the same budget asked the same question and came up with a different map, which one of you would be right?

3. Brighton and Brentford England / Premier League and Championship

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

English football clubs spend heavily on recruitment. The assumption underneath that spending is consistent: the more you pay for known players, the better your squad. Brighton and Hove Albion and Brentford both operated on a different premise. Their competitive advantage came from identifying value where other clubs were not looking, rather than competing for value everyone had already priced.

Brighton, under owner Tony Bloom and a data science infrastructure built around evidence-based recruitment, generated approximately £340 million in net transfer profit between 2020 and 2024, the highest of any Premier League club over that period (Swiss Ramble; Matchday Finance). The model is not about youth development in the traditional sense. It is about identifying players other clubs have mispriced, signing them at undervalued rates and selling them at market rate once their value has been realised.

The structural logic is precise. Brighton deploy analytical models to markets other Premier League clubs underweight: the lower French divisions, the Belgian Pro League, the Portuguese Primeira Liga. The question guiding the process is not which players have the strongest reputation but which players are undervalued relative to what the data shows they can become. Fabian Hurzeler, appointed manager in June 2024, continues operating within that framework.

Brentford's model during their B-team era (2016 to 2022) applied the same logic at a different level. Following Matthew Benham's decision to close the youth academy and replace it with a B team operating on a fraction of the previous budget, Brentford produced a significant number of first-team graduates and generated transfer revenue from players other clubs had overlooked. Brentford relaunched their academy in 2022, beginning with Category 2 status across U9 to U16 age groups.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

Brighton's transfer activity between 2020 and 2024 tells the story directly. Moises Caicedo was signed for approximately £5 million and sold to Chelsea for £115 million. Marc Cucurella was sold to Chelsea for approximately £62 million. Alexis Mac Allister was bought for approximately £7 million and sold to Liverpool for approximately £35 million. Net profit over the period: approximately £340 million, the highest in the Premier League (Swiss Ramble; Matchday Finance).

From Brentford's B-team era: Ollie Watkins sold to Aston Villa for approximately £28 million, Said Benrahma to West Ham for approximately £22 million, Neal Maupay to Brighton for approximately £20 million. All developed through a structure that cost a fraction of a Category 1 academy budget.

THE PRINCIPLE

When you treat recruitment as a search for mispriced value rather than a competition for known talent, the return is structurally higher because you are not bidding against the market. Brighton and Brentford did not find better players. They found players other clubs had not valued correctly.

AT YOUR LEVEL

Where does your programme currently recruit and what is the evidence base for that decision? Not the historical rationale, but the current evidence: what data, what scouting process, what framework tells you the players you are identifying are undervalued relative to what they can become?

If you asked that question of your current squad, how many players were recruited because they were genuinely identified as mispriced and how many were recruited because they were recommended by someone your programme already trusted?

4. Right to Dream Ghana / Denmark / Egypt / USA

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

English academy football operates on an implicit assumption about time. Players pulled from school to train. Education treated as something that happens around development, not alongside it. The hours are finite and the choices are either/or. Right to Dream was founded on the rejection of that assumption.

Tom Vernon, a former professional player and Manchester United scout, founded Right to Dream in Accra, Ghana in 1999. His argument was specific: educated players make better decisions on and off the pitch. The programme he built does not make development and academic education compete for the same hours. It runs them simultaneously. Players in the Right to Dream system receive a full secondary school education as a condition of participation, not as a welfare consideration.

Right to Dream acquired FC Nordsjaelland in Denmark in 2015, creating a direct professional pathway from the Ghana academy to top-flight European football. The model has since expanded. Right to Dream Egypt opened in 2023. A partnership with San Diego FC provides a pathway into MLS. In December 2025, the Globe Soccer Award for Best Academy was presented to Right to Dream, accepted by Sir Mohamed Mansour and awarded by Rio Ferdinand. The citation described the programme as the most visionary youth organisation in global football (globesoccer.com, December 2025).

The programme has been profiled by Harvard Business School as a case study in social enterprise and sustainable development. The academic credibility is not incidental. It reflects the model's central argument: the binary choice between education and football is a structural assumption, not a physical necessity.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

Mohammed Kudus developed at Right to Dream before moving to FC Nordsjaelland, then Ajax, then West Ham. Kamaldeen Sulemana and Ernest Nuamah followed the same Ghana to Nordsjaelland pipeline before moving into senior European football. Seven Right to Dream graduates represented their nations at the 2022 FIFA World Cup (Right to Dream, 2022). The Mansour Group has invested more than $180 million in the programme since acquiring it in 2021 (Mansour Group communications).

The model that produced those outcomes runs full academic education alongside elite development. The two are not in competition. They are the same programme.

THE PRINCIPLE

Education is not in competition with player development. It is part of it. Right to Dream's results are not the output of generosity. They are the output of a structural decision about what a player needs to develop well.

AT YOUR LEVEL

The binary choice between football and education in your programme is a structural decision, not a practical necessity. What would it cost to run both simultaneously? Not in resources, but in assumption.

Right to Dream's pipeline runs from Ghana to Denmark to Europe and MLS. Your programme's pipeline is different. But the question it asks is the same: what does a young player actually need to develop? And are those things genuinely in competition with each other?

5. Benfica Portugal / Primeira Liga

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

Most English academies operate across multiple sites. Different age groups in different locations. Coaches who meet at monthly staff meetings rather than daily on the same training pitch. A development philosophy that travels from head office to individual coaches via documents, inductions and annual reviews. The coherence of the programme depends on how well the message travels.

Benfica built their academy on a different structural premise. The Caixa Futebol Campus in Seixal covers 19 hectares. Every age group from U6 to the B team trains on the same site. The campus includes 9 football pitches, a school, residential accommodation, sports science laboratories and the facilities for Benfica B, their reserve team that competes in the Portuguese second division. The U12 coach and the head of the first-team squad operate in the same environment every day. The philosophy doesn't need to be sent anywhere because the people who carry it are always in the same place.

That co-location produces something documents and away days cannot: daily visibility of the full pathway. When phase leads share a building, they watch each other's sessions. They talk about players moving through the system before those players arrive. The transition from academy to B team to first team is not a structural discontinuity. It happens on the same site, under the same roof, between coaches who already know each other.

The technical philosophy reflects the same logic. Benfica do not introduce positional systems until U14 to U15. The earlier years build technical quality that the later years build on. The B team in Liga 2 provides competitive senior football inside the same structure before players graduate.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

Benfica have generated over €500 million in transfer revenue from academy graduates since 2015, the highest of any club worldwide by CIES Football Observatory estimates. Notable graduates include Joao Felix (sold to Atletico Madrid for approximately €126 million), Ruben Dias (sold to Manchester City for approximately £62 million) and Darwin Nunez (sold to Liverpool for approximately £85 million). Bernardo Silva developed at Benfica before Monaco and then Manchester City.

The economic output is the consequence of the infrastructure. One campus, one philosophy, one clear pathway from U6 to first team. The clubs Benfica compete against in the transfer market spend more. They don't produce more.

THE PRINCIPLE

Co-location enforces the kind of consistency that documents cannot. English academies that spread operations across multiple sites create a coordination problem that no philosophy document solves. The Benfica campus is the argument that proximity does what paperwork cannot.

AT YOUR LEVEL

How many of your coaches across different age groups have watched each other's sessions in the last month? Not in a formal observation context. In passing, because they share a building and a training pitch.

If you asked your U14 lead coach today what your U18 players are working on technically, could they answer without making a call?

6. Red Bull Network Austria / Germany / USA / Brazil

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

Most academies develop players for one club. The player learns one system, one style, one coaching environment. When they move to a bigger club, they start again. They adapt to a new game model, new terminology, new expectations. The transition is a disruption.

Red Bull operates a network of clubs under a single unified game model: RB Salzburg, RB Leipzig, New York Red Bulls, Red Bull Bragantino in Brazil, with FC Liefering functioning as a dedicated feeder club for Salzburg in the Austrian league. The same development philosophy, the same pressing triggers, the same positional structure and the same coaching vocabulary runs across every age group at every club in the network.

A player developing at Salzburg and moving to Leipzig doesn't adapt to a new system. They step up within the same one. The environment travels with them. FC Liefering exists specifically to provide competitive senior football within the network structure before Salzburg graduates are ready for the first team. It serves the same function as Benfica B, built into the structure from the start.

Red Bull took over the licence of what became RB Leipzig in 2009, when the club was in the fifth tier of German football. Leipzig reached the Bundesliga in 2016-17, seven seasons later. Their first Champions League appearance came in 2017-18, eight seasons after the club's formation under Red Bull ownership.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

The network has produced players sold at significant fees who demonstrated the system's capacity to develop at the highest level. Dominik Szoboszlai moved from Salzburg to Leipzig to Liverpool, sold for approximately £60 million. Karim Adeyemi moved from Salzburg to Borussia Dortmund for approximately €30 million. Erling Haaland developed at Salzburg before Borussia Dortmund. The transfer logic runs in one direction: develop within the network, sell upward.

The most contested element of the Red Bull model is its ownership structure. Critics argue it prioritises commercial identity over authentic development. The structural argument is separable from that criticism: a unified game model applied consistently across clubs and age groups is not contingent on Red Bull's ownership. It is a structural decision any club can make.

THE PRINCIPLE

When every age group at every level of the pathway understands the same game model, player transitions stop being disruptions and become progressions. The investment in a unified philosophy pays out every time a player moves up without needing to start again.

AT YOUR LEVEL

If you asked every coach in your programme to describe your game model independently, would they describe the same model? Not a similar one. The same one.

If the answer is no, the problem is not a communication failure. It is a structural one. The Red Bull solution was to make the model the constant across four clubs on three continents. Your solution is simpler: a single written game model that every coach in your programme has read, understood and can apply.

Technical directors and independent consultants

Models 7–8

7. Ajax / De Toekomst Netherlands / Eredivisie

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

Most academies assign positions early. A promising eight-year-old with good spatial awareness becomes a central midfielder. A tall, dominant ten-year-old becomes a centre-back. The position shapes the development from that point: the training, the coaching focus, the benchmark for progress. Ajax asked what happens if you don't do that.

The Ajax academy philosophy, developed at De Toekomst (The Future) training complex which opened in 1996, is built on position-agnostic development in the early years. Players learn every role before they specialise. The argument is specific: a player who understands what a winger needs from a central midfielder makes better decisions as a central midfielder. Understanding the full game from every position produces better specialists than early lock-in to a single role.

The TIPS framework governs assessment across every age group: Technique, Insight, Personality and Speed. It applies before any positional assignment. A player's fundamental cognitive and technical capacities are developed first. Positional identity follows. The framework is documented in academic literature and has been a consistent reference point in European coaching education.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

Approximately 30% of Eredivisie players at any given point have passed through De Toekomst at some stage in their development (press-verified, multiple sources). Recent graduates who developed within the system include Frenkie de Jong, Matthijs de Ligt and Ryan Gravenberch, each sold at fees that reflected development within the Ajax model. The 1995 Champions League-winning squad and the 2018-19 Champions League run both emerged from the same philosophical foundation.

This entry includes something the others do not: an honest account of where the model has struggled. Following Erik ten Hag's departure for Manchester United in 2022, Ajax experienced significant coaching turnover and a period of poor results. The TIPS framework and position-agnostic philosophy did not change. The continuity of people applying it did. The lesson is structural: a development philosophy is not self-sustaining. It requires people who carry it, protect it and apply it consistently over years. When those people leave in quick succession, the philosophy exists on paper rather than in practice.

THE PRINCIPLE

Position-agnostic development is not an argument against specialisation. It is an argument for sequencing. Understand the game first. Specialise within that understanding second. Players who can only play their position are limited by what they know. Players who understand every position are limited only by how well they execute their own.

AT YOUR LEVEL

What positions do your coaches fully understand? Not just their own role. The positions they coach adjacent to and the positions players are moving into as they progress through your system.

If your central midfielders at U16 understood what your wingers and your defensive midfielders needed from them, would their decision-making look different? Would your coaching of them look different?

8. Athletic Bilbao / Lezama Spain / La Liga

THE STRUCTURAL DECISION

The default assumption in professional football recruitment is that wider is better. More markets, more scouting, more options. Athletic Bilbao operate on the opposite premise and have done so continuously since 1932.

Athletic Bilbao field only players from the Basque Country. Not players who have passed through their academy. Players who are Basque, by birth or by formation in the region. No exceptions have been made. The policy is not a financial constraint or a temporary positioning decision. It is the club's founding principle, applied without compromise across more than ninety years of professional football.

The result is the longest unbroken record in Spanish football outside Real Madrid and Barcelona. Athletic Bilbao have been in La Liga continuously since 1932. They have never been relegated. They have achieved this with a recruitment pool that eliminates the overwhelming majority of professional footballers on the planet.

The structural mechanism behind that record is Lezama. The Lezama complex, 13 kilometres from Bilbao, has functioned as a national development centre for the Basque Country since 1971. It currently houses 15 youth teams from U12 to U19, including Bilbao Athletic, the club's reserve side that competes in the lower professional divisions. September 2021 saw the opening of new residential accommodation at Lezama: 30 double rooms with customisable furnishings, designed to give young players genuine agency over their living environment. The investment in a residence reflects the model's logic: if the best Basque players know that Lezama is their environment, the environment has to be worth choosing.

WHAT IT PRODUCED

Athletic Bilbao's policy creates a regional development network that no other model in this document produces. Every grassroots club in the Basque Country knows that Athletic Bilbao is the ceiling available to their players. That knowledge drives investment in coaching quality, in facilities and in the technical development of young players across the entire region. The club doesn't just benefit from the network. The policy is what creates it.

The constraint is the system. Because Athletic Bilbao cannot recruit outside the Basque Country, every structural decision they make is designed to extract maximum development from the talent that exists within it. The Lezama complex, the partner club network across the region and the direct pathway to Bilbao Athletic are all expressions of one question: how do we develop the best possible Basque players?

THE PRINCIPLE

A constraint treated as a limit produces a smaller version of what a club without the constraint would build. A constraint treated as a design parameter produces something designed specifically for the conditions it operates in. Athletic Bilbao's ninety-year La Liga record is what the second approach looks like across time.

AT YOUR LEVEL

Your programme operates within constraints: budget, geography, category, staffing. The Athletic Bilbao question is whether those constraints are being treated as limits or as design parameters.

What would your programme look like if every structural decision you made was designed specifically for the constraints you actually have, rather than approximating what a programme without those constraints would build?

Glossary

EPPP
Elite Player Performance Plan. The framework introduced by the Premier League in 2012 that governs the structure, funding and oversight of professional academy football in England. Academies are categorised from Category 1 to Category 4.

Category 1 to 4
The grading system within the EPPP framework. Category 1 academies receive the highest annual funding from the Premier League and operate the largest full-time staff and facility requirements. Category 2 and 3 academies receive proportionally less. Category 4 applies to clubs outside the professional game.

UEFA Pro Licence
The highest coaching qualification issued by UEFA, required for managers of clubs competing in UEFA competitions and the top domestic divisions of most European countries. The full pathway from UEFA B to UEFA Pro Licence costs approximately £20,000 in England.

B team
A reserve or development team that competes in a competitive professional or semi-professional league, providing senior football for players who have completed academy development but are not yet ready for first-team football. Distinct from an under-23 development squad in that B teams compete against senior opposition in league competition.

Sell-on clause
A contractual provision in a transfer agreement that entitles the selling club to a percentage of any future transfer fee if the buying club sells the player on.

CIES Football Observatory
The Centre International d'Etude du Sport, based in Neuchatel, Switzerland. Produces independent research on professional football including transfer economics, academy output and player demographics. Their academy graduate transfer revenue rankings are the most widely cited independent measure of academy productivity in European football.

Eredivisie
The top division of professional football in the Netherlands.

Danish Superliga
The top division of professional football in Denmark. FC Midtjylland won four Superliga titles between 2015 and 2024: 2014-15, 2017-18, 2019-20 and 2023-24.

Eight clubs. Eight structural decisions. Eight different answers to versions of the same question: what does a programme actually need to develop players well?

None of the models in this document is replicable in full. The Benfica campus costs more than most English Category 1 budgets. The Red Bull network requires multi-club ownership. Right to Dream's pipeline runs across two continents. What is replicable, in every case, is the structural question each model asked before it built anything.

The Architecture Audit ends where it started: with the choices already running in your programme. Some of them are deliberate. Some of them are inherited. The value of studying the models in this document is not that they tell you what to build. It is that they sharpen the questions you ask about what you are already running.

If one of these models has identified a structural choice in your programme that deserves a closer look, that is the place to start. Not with a restructure. With a question.

If you want to work through what that looks like for your specific programme, that is what I do.

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